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Odegaard. Guimaraes' departure was the final blow for the Magpies, who have been gradually hollowed out, with Anthony Gordon, Sandro Tonali and manager Eddie Howe all bidding goodbye.

Meanwhile, Manchester City and Chelsea made their intentions to challenge for the title clear by practically breaking the bank on English talents Elliot Anderson and Morgan Rogers, respectively. Enzo Maresca will have the harder job of living up to the legacy of Pep Guardiola and ensuring the club does not buckle like its neighbour did post-Alex Ferguson. For Xabi Alonso, on the other hand, the Chelsea job comes as a fresh start, and the club will be expected to be among the leaders, especially with no Europe for distractions.

Legacy clubs Liverpool and Manchester United, too, will be hoping to stay in the mix, with the former set to step on the pitch without talismanic Mohamed Salah for the first time in nine years. Head coach Andoni Iraola, who replaced Arne Slot, has proven himself with Bournemouth, but it remains to be seen how he adjusts to the weight of expectation hanging over him all the time.

For United, Michael Carrick has unlocked the potential of the team, as seen in the second half of last season, but with more games — including the Champions League — and less time between them, he will not have it quite as easy.

Tottenham Hotspur, the final member of the 'Big Six', is on the rebuild after two consecutive 17th-place finishes, penning deals with Sandro Tonali, Mateus Fernandes, Jan Paul van Hecke, Marcos Senesi and Andy Robertson. Moreover, Spurs will have the sprightly figure of Roberto De Zerbi on the sidelines, who came in late last edition and rescued them from the clutches of relegation.



Summer shuffle: Chelsea has lost the services of Alejandro Garnacho (above, right) to Aston Villa, and Marc Cucurella (below), who helped Spain win the World Cup before moving to Real Madrid. REUTERS & AFP

Meanwhile, trying to get into that 'Big Six' club will be Aston Villa, which has been highly impressive in recent years under Unai Emery. While the departure of Rogers might hamper the setup, ample reinforcements have been brought in the form of World Cup breakout star Johan Manzambi and Alejandro Garnacho, who will be raring to prove his worth.

Coming to the new faces, Coventry City, Hull City and Ipswich will be seeking to emulate the success of their predecessors Leeds United and Sunderland, who, last season, broke the concerning pattern of all promoted teams going back down. For Frank Lampard-led Coventry, especially, the return comes after 25 years, and they will be expected to do whatever it takes to hold their spot.

Meanwhile, the mid-table contingent of Fulham (Alvaro Arbeloa), Bournemouth (Marco Rose), Crystal Palace (Pierre Sage),

